3.13 Connection Preference

Since there are two ways to set your connection, via environment variable it is important to understand how the two can interact.

If you have an empty `config/database.yml` file but your `ENV['DATABASE_URL']` is present, then Rails will connect to the database via your environment variable:

```
$ cat config/database.yml

$ echo $DATABASE_URL
postgresql://localhost/my_database
```

If you have a `config/database.yml` but no `ENV['DATABASE_URL']` then this file will be used to connect to your database:

```
$ cat config/database.yml
development:
  adapter: postgresql
  database: my_database
  host: localhost

$ echo $DATABASE_URL
```

If you have both `config/database.yml` and `ENV['DATABASE_URL']` set then Rails will merge the configuration together. To better understand this we must see some examples.

When duplicate connection information is provided the environment variable will take precedence:

```
$ cat config/database.yml
development:
  adapter: sqlite3
  database: NOT_my_database
  host: localhost

$ echo $DATABASE_URL
postgresql://localhost/my_database

$ bin/rails runner 'puts ActiveRecord::Base.configurations'
{"development"=>{"adapter"=>"postgresql", "host"=>"localhost",
"database"=>"my_database"}}
```

Here the adapter, host, and database match the information in `ENV['DATABASE_URL']`.

If non-duplicate information is provided you will get all unique values, environment variable still takes precedence in cases of any conflicts.

```
$ cat config/database.yml
development:
  adapter: sqlite3
  pool: 5

$ echo $DATABASE_URL
postgresql://localhost/my_database

$ bin/rails runner 'puts ActiveRecord::Base.configurations'
{"development"=>{"adapter"=>"postgresql", "host"=>"localhost",
"database"=>"my_database", "pool"=>5}}
```

Since pool is not in the `ENV['DATABASE_URL']` provided connection information its information is merged in. Since `adapter` is duplicate, the `ENV['DATABASE_URL']` connection information wins.

The only way to explicitly not use the connection information in `ENV['DATABASE_URL']` is to specify an explicit URL connection using the `"url"` sub key:

```
$ cat config/database.yml
development:
  url: sqlite3:NOT_my_database
```